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I. Introduction

On behalf of the French Republic, the President would like to thank this body for its consideration of the French positions on the issues to be addressed on the agenda: Boosting European Competitiveness and Advancing European Defensive Capabilities.

Europe faces increasing challenges that threaten its economic strength and security. Productivity gaps, fragmented investment frameworks, and regulatory complexity weaken the EU's ability to compete on a global scale. Rising geopolitical tensions, continued attacks on EU''s borders, and evolving security threats highlight the need for sustained and coordinated investment in European defensive capabilities. The challenges of competitiveness and defense are deeply interconnected, as economic competitiveness is foundational to autonomy, and strong defensive capabilities depend on an equally strong industrial and technological capability within the EU.

France believes that addressing these issues requires a coordinated European response that strengthens innovation, investment, and energy security while reinforcing long-term defense readiness and industrial cooperation. Through this approach, France seeks to advance a European Union that is competitive, secure, and capable of safeguarding its sovereignty in an increasingly unstable global environment.

II. Boosting European Competitiveness

Economic prosperity is the key to maintaining sovereignty, and the EU must not only deliver on the current competitiveness agenda but accelerate it. To do so, France, alongside Germany, proposes a new coordination format for the leading EU economies to align national industrial and investment priorities in strategic areas, enabling more innovation and investment and a smarter, streamlined regulatory framework.[1] This proposal focuses on the Savings and Investment Union (SIU), which mobilizes private investments by unifying funds across the EU. To make it easier for European businesses to access investment funds, the EU must reduce bureaucratic red tape and better coordinate investment in defence sectors and the securing of critical raw materials.[2]

Energy independence is at the forefront of enhancing European competitiveness. France, alongside Germany, calls for an energy reset at the EU level focused on climate neutrality, competitiveness and sovereignty. This reset includes a technology-neutral approach to energy policy, ensuring non-discrimination among all low-carbon energy sources, including nuclear. France supports EU energy and financing frameworks that treat nuclear power the same as other low-carbon technologies, allowing all member states to use a diversified mix of energy sources to maintain affordability and competitiveness while meeting EU climate goals.

In addition to energy, France has committed to investing in research, innovation, and industrial scale-up. France has identified the need to focus investment in strategic sectors where Europe risks falling behind, including artificial intelligence, quantum computing, semiconductors, clean energy, and defense. These areas are not only drivers of economic growth

[1] https://www.elysee.fr/en/emmanuel-macron/2025/05/07/a-franco-german-reset-for-europe
[2]https://www.reuters.com/world/china/german-french-ministers-aim-boost-eu-competitiveness-with-new-format-2026-01-27/

but essential to Europe's technological leadership and security. France supports EU industrial policy tools, including targeted state aid, streamlined approval processes and faster timelines, and Important Projects of Common European Interest (IPCEIs) to accelerate the development and deployment of new technologies, ensuring that the EU remains competitive and resilient.[3]

III. Advancing European Defensive Capabilities

France believes in a deterrence-first security approach to European defense. Long-term investments in military strength are at the center of French defense policy. France has committed to a €36 billion increase in defence spending over 2026-2030, including €3.5 billion to be allocated this year. This funding is intended to strengthen France's military capability, with a focus on force readiness, ammunition stockpiles, and cybersecurity to guarantee French security and contribute to the security of Europe as a whole.[4] These investments reflect France's assessment that the European security environment has deteriorated and that long-term investment is needed to restore preparedness over short-term plans.[5]

To further enhance the security of Europe, defence capability development must take into account the existing transatlantic security framework. France and Germany have committed to strengthening their defence capabilities to strengthen the European pillar of NATO. France views this approach as complementary to the Alliance, as a stronger European contribution will improve the EU's ability to defend itself while also strengthening NATO's overall deterrence and collective defence posture.

France, alongside Germany, is focused not only on strengthening military capability but also on reinforcing the European defense industry. France supports prioritizing European-made military equipment to limit dependencies on non-EU sources and improve the European defense market. Industrial capacity for defense will directly translate to sustained military capability and long-term security, especially in times of crisis when supply chains may be disrupted.

In addition to strengthening the European defense market, France and Germany also believe in the need to reduce fragmentation within European defense systems. To improve effectiveness, the EU should identify the numerous defense systems across Europe and identify opportunities for standardization and coordination to ensure compatibility among European armed forces and streamline dense spending. To improve coordination, France and Germany have agreed to establish regular Cabinet meetings on strategic, defence, and national security measures. These meetings coordinate military aid to countries like Ukraine, align defence planning and production, and advance shared goals. France views this bilateral framework as a model that could be expanded at the EU level to unify defensive goals and improve implementation across Europe.[6]

IV. Conclusion/Closing Remarks

The Republic of France reiterates its gratitude to this diplomatic body for carefully considering its positions on these pressing issues, and hopes to continue to work towards policies which advance the democratic ideals that this Union is founded upon.

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[3]https://www.elysee.fr/en/emmanuel-macron/2024/05/29/a-new-agenda-to-boost-competitiveness-and-growth-in-the-european-union

[4]https://www.euronews.com/2026/01/15/to-remain-free-one-must-be-feared-macron-says-of-francees-defence-priorities

[5] https://www.sgdsn.gouv.fr/files/files/Publications/20250713_NP_SGDSN_RNS2025_EN_0.pdf

[6] https://www.elysee.fr/en/emmanuel-macron/2025/05/07/a-franco-german-reset-for-europe